

OCR Tips

- Always choose a scanner that has a white surface under the lid—this will give more accurate results.
- Always keep the document flat, and see that there are no wrinkles or folded corners—this may produce black patches.
- Look for de-skew and despeckle options. This will give more accurate images and also increase the accuracy of OCR software.
- Do not scan a document with black fonts on white background in line-art mode; it will return very poor results. The results will not improve even if you increase the resolution. Use greyscale mode instead.
- 48-bit setting at 200-dpi is more than enough for most new OCR software. If the document has images, increase the resolution to 300-dpi, and preserve the format of the document.

Hotkeys

Scan to Fax: This lets users fax documents using an application that comes bundled with the scanner. It needs a telephone (not a fax

machine), connected to a PC through a modem. This transmission uses the TAPI protocol.

Scan to Print/Copy: This allows users to print a scanned document directly from a locally connected or network printer. The document is saved as an image, which can be used later. This saves you the trouble of initialising the printer program to take the print-out.

Scan to e-mail: This feature lets users mail the scanned document directly. The moment the Scan-to-mail button is pressed the system initialises the default mail client. Type in an e-mail address, and hey presto, the scanned document gets mailed instantly.

Scan to OCR: This is a new addition that's becoming quite common. It scans the document and initialises the OCR software. Scanners that have this feature are usually bundled with an older or light version of OCR software.

Scan to CD: This relatively new feature scans the document and burns it directly onto a CD, saving lots of hard disk space, and imparting mobility to your data.

Scan to Post: This scans the image and posts it directly to a Web page. You save on the time taken to open a browser, typing in the Web address, and uploading the image.



The Future of Scanners

With the growing popularity of digital cameras, scanners have been pushed out of the average home user's shopping list. However, quite a few users still feel the need for one, especially the flatbed models. They are used to turn paper documents into files, digitise photos and e-mail them, make reprints, and upload images to Web sites. In the business sector, scanners help to create brochures, presentations and Web content. There's never been a better time than now to purchase a quality scanner at a low price.

Flatbed scanners are the most in demand as compared to other types, primarily because they can easily scan bound documents such as books and magazines. Several flatbed models now offer automatic document feeder (ADF) attachments and can scan transparencies and film negatives as well. As a result, both sheet-fed scanners (which scan loose pages) and handheld scanners (that require users to move them across a document manually) are now almost history.

The popularity of flatbed scanners can be expected to grow as manufacturers make more improvements in design and ease of use. Look for the incorporation of one-touch button functionality, which allow users to bypass the process of using software programs to perform specific functions. A good

option is the one-button approach that automatically completes tasks, such as sending a scan directly to a printer, or faxing a scan.



Another improvement that will definitely continue is the increased number of scanners using a USB port to connect to computers, rather than parallel ports. USB connections are easier to use and provide faster scan rates. It is also likely that mid-range and high-end models will continue to include a SCSI connection, which are even faster, but require users to install a SCSI controller card inside the computer.

In the future, you can expect to see an increased availability of speciality scanners as well as multifunction devices (MFDs) with scanning abilities. Specifically, look for the digital-imaging craze to catch on so that models are expressly designed to scan existing film photos, 35 mm negatives and slides. These models will scan at a higher resolution, produce better results and provide users with an alternative to buying a digital camera.

However, scanner prices are unlikely to fall much lower than they are today. Today's models represent great value—and are an asset for any serious computer user.



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